

Composite vs. Hardwood Decking.

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Short version: composite costs more per board and less per decade. Hardwood looks and feels like nothing else — if you'll actually maintain it. Here's how they compare at Colorado altitude, where UV and freeze-thaw cycles punish both.

	Composite	Hardwood
Installed cost	\$95–125 / sq ft	\$115–150 / sq ft
Annual upkeep	Soap and water	Clean, sand spots, re-oil every 1–2 yrs
Lifespan	25–50 yrs (warrantied)	20–40 yrs (maintained)
Colorado UV	Fade-warrantied caps	Silvers fast without oil
Feel underfoot	Warmer in full sun	Cooler, real wood grain

Pick composite if...

You want weekends on the deck, not maintaining it. Modern capped boards (Trex, TimberTech, Deckorators — we install all three) have real 25–50 year fade and stain warranties, and at 5,000+ ft that matters: our UV is roughly 25% stronger than sea level. About 90% of what we build is composite.

Pick hardwood if...

Nothing else will do. Ipe and cumaru are gorgeous, dense, and cooler underfoot. The honest trade: budget a re-oil every year or two, or accept the silver-gray patina. Skip the middle ground — a neglected hardwood deck costs more to rescue than it did to build.

What about redwood or cedar?

The budget-friendly classic. Lower upfront cost (\$85–110 / sq ft installed), but softer boards and yearly staining in our climate. Fine for ground-level decks you plan to replace in 15–20 years; we'd steer walk-outs and high decks to composite.